

Wooden fort
The fort at Lunt near Coventry in England is a reconstruction of one built there in the 1st century CE. The design of the gate tower is based on examples on Trajan's Column.

Although legionaries spent only a fraction of their time on active service, warfare was in the end what they were for. Probably most men welcomed campaigning as a chance to escape the dull routine of garrison duties and to put into practice the military skills endlessly rehearsed in training. Campaigns mostly involved the aggressive movement of forces into hostile territory in response to a revolt within the empire or attacks from outside it. The aim was punitive – to inflict such spectacular suffering and destruction on those responsible that the incidents would not recur.

The legionary was expected to march at a speed of around 6kph (4mph) under normal circumstances, and faster if a crisis required it. But the practical speed of movement of Roman forces was set by their supply wagons, pack animals, and siege train. The logistical arrangements of Roman legions were generally excellent and both soldiers and animals could expect to be reasonably fed while on campaign, although a certain amount of foraging along the route was normal. Sometimes on punitive expeditions the main function of the legionaries was to devastate the area around the march, destroying crops and animals and laying waste to villages and towns. This was a task Roman soldiers performed with thoroughness and conscience-free brutality.

CONSTRUCTION DUTIES

At the end of every day the legionaries would construct a marching camp, a temporary defensive position surrounded by a rampart and ditch. The back-breaking work of digging ditches and building ramparts to establish the camp was done by contingents drawn from all the centuries involved in the campaign – perhaps ten men from each. Marching near the head of the column, these men would aim to have the site ready by the time their colleagues, near the rear of the column, arrived looking for rest.

Faced with natural obstacles, legions on the march would sometimes demonstrate impressive engineering skills. During his first campaign against the Dacians in 101 CE, Emperor Trajan's army crossed the Danube on a rapidly constructed bridge of boats. But returning for a second

> "I GIVE THANKS ... THAT WHILE ALL ARE WORKING HARD THE WHOLE DAY CUTTING STONES, I AS A PRINCIPALIS GO ABOUT DOING NOTHING."
>
> **ROMAN SOLDIER** STATIONED IN EGYPT IN A LETTER TO HIS FAMILY, 109 CE



Arch of Trajan, Thamugadi, Algeria
While legionaries built magnificent paved roads across the empire, emperors erected memorials to their military triumphs. This arch in a once prosperous North African city commemorates Trajan's victories over the Parthians in 114–117 CE.